Helen Devine
Cornell Psychology PhD Academic Statement of Purpose

As a social psychologist, I hope to study how people make judgments about victimhood and blame, especially when lay judgments contradict legal standards. My past research experiences have given me extensive preparation and Cornell's Social and Personality Psychology PhD program is the best place for me to conduct graduate training.

I began exploring social psychology during my freshman year at the University of Michigan, where I worked as a study coordinator in Dr. Amie Gordon's Well-Being, Health, and Interpersonal Relationships Lab on a large-scale longitudinal study of how romantic couples navigate stress. I designed recruitment to bring 218 couples into the lab, ran in-person lab sessions using the Trier Social Stress Test, collected biopsychological data (continuous heart rate, blood pressure, salivary hormones), and coordinated a subsequent two-week daily diary. I also ran follow-ups for a year to track changes in relational quality over time. Learning to manage multiple physiological methods gave me an early foundation in rigorous experimental design.

Before my junior year, I was selected as Dr. Gordon's lab manager, a position typically reserved for post-baccalaureates. In collaboration with Dr. Robin Edelstein, I helped launch a study on how romantic couples adapt to first-time parenting by caring for an infant simulator for a weekend. I oversaw the collection of over 2,000 saliva samples and trained our team on an enzyme-linked immunosorbent assay technique. We found that couples with positive expectations about parenting showed decreased testosterone when caring for the infant simulator, suggesting that optimism helps parents adapt more readily to a nurturing role. I am a co-author on the manuscript with an R&R in *Human Nature*. My early work at Michigan showed me how human judgments are shaped by emotion and expectations.

My interest in high-stakes decision-making under social pressure took shape through my senior honors thesis. I designed two experiments and secured $4,000 in independent funding to test whether the presence of a close friend makes people less likely to comply with an intrusive phone search request ("Can you please unlock your phone and hand it to me?"). Participants overwhelmingly handed over their phones—whether alone or with a friend—despite predicting that they would not comply. Additionally, even bystanders showed heightened physiological arousal (e.g., spiked systolic blood pressure) when watching their friends comply, providing evidence that intrusive requests evoke a stress response that likely affects behavior. This work showed me how consequential decisions are guided more by intuition than deliberation. I presented this work as a talk at the 2025 *Society for Personality and Social Psychology* legal psychology pre-conference, received the faculty-nominated Pillsbury Award for best thesis, and graduated with Highest Honors. Leading this project from design to dissemination confirmed that moral and legal research is where I feel most at home.

To expand my training, I earned a lab manager position in Dr. Kurt Gray's Deepest Beliefs Lab at UNC Chapel Hill, which later moved to The Ohio State University. In an ongoing first-authored project, I am investigating whether fear of crime increases victim-blaming. My results suggest that those who fear victimization are more likely to blame victims, potentially to resolve cognitive dissonance. This suggests that efforts to raise awareness about crime may inadvertently

increase blame rather than protect victims. I have presented these findings at two national conferences and expanded the project into an NSF Graduate Research Fellowship application. I aim to use this research to reduce victim-blaming by targeting how crime is reported nationally.

Alongside my empirical work with Dr. Gray, I co-authored an accepted piece in *Policy Insights from the Behavioral and Brain Sciences* to provide psychological insights for the justice system. We propose that perceptions of victimhood, which tend to be biased, intuitive, and hard to change, often directly conflict with legal expectations, which treat victimhood as objective and unbiased. This piece reinforced my passion for making science effective for laypeople.

These experiences have motivated me to pursue graduate training to study moral judgments in legal contexts. Cornell's program is the ideal place for me to develop this work, and I am especially excited about the possibility of being advised by Dr. David Pizarro. Dr. Pizarro's research on the zero-sum relationship between victim and perpetrator blame directly informs my interest in how fear shapes judgments of victims. My work replicates this pattern, finding that the more people fear crime, the more they blame victims and the less they blame perpetrators. During my honors thesis, I also found that participants facing an intrusive consent request showed a more significant physiological reaction when seated with a friend. Dr. Pizarro's work offers an explanation of their stress response: participants may have interpreted their friend's compliance as a signal of moral character and questioned their trustworthiness. I hope to extend this work by examining how affective cues—whether internal (fear of crime, stress) or external (true crime, legal searches)—shape judgments of blame. Dr. Pizarro's expertise in emotional influences on moral cognition makes his lab a strong fit for the questions I hope to pursue.

I also see opportunities for collaboration with Dr. Jordan Wylie, whose research on curiosity about morally transgressive content aligns with my interest in true crime media. I am interested in whether the appeal of true crime reflects moral curiosity rather than the commonly stated need to "prepare for victimization," and whether consuming true crime influences perceptions of victims as blameworthy. I also hope to collaborate with Dr. Jessica Salerno, whose research on victim emotionality and juror decision-making complements my interests in how people evaluate victims in high-stakes situations. Her research intersects morality and legal judgments—precisely where I hope to focus.

Cornell's emphasis on moral psychology, law, and rigorous methods make it uniquely suited for my goals. The opportunity to work across labs with complementary strengths would allow me to investigate how moral intuitions operate in everyday reasoning and in consequential institutional contexts. I am excited by the prospect of contributing to this community and pursuing the questions that draw me to study moral judgment.

Helen Devine
Cornell Psychology PhD Personal Statement of Interest

When I was nine, my favorite show *Gilmore Girls* introduced me to a Latin motto that I've carried far beyond my childhood home's living room: *In omnia paratus*, "Ready for anything." At the time, it pushed me to live boldly and openly: on the soccer field, in my student government, and in the classroom. As I moved through college—balancing jobs with school, stepping into leadership roles, and pursuing research—it became my quiet philosophy. When I discovered social psychology in my freshman year at the University of Michigan, I found a field that shared my outlook and required openness to complex questions and perspectives. This led me to moral psychology, where judgments of right and wrong vary widely and shape our deepest decisions. I am ready to explore these questions deeply in graduate training with the resilience and openness that has always guided me.

The moment I knew I wanted to pursue a PhD came during my honors thesis, when a team of my research assistants and I experienced a finding that reshaped my understanding of social behavior. I was studying whether people would comply with intrusive search requests, and participants were agreeing to hand over their unlocked phones to a research assistant without hesitation—despite 64% of people previously saying they would never give a stranger their phone. On one of our first trials, my research assistant burst into the lab, wide-eyed with disbelief. Our shared excitement over the visible and striking gap between intentions and actions made it clear to me that research was not just something I enjoyed, it was the environment in which I felt most at home.

Leading my thesis also solidified my belief that mentorship is one of the most meaningful parts of being a researcher. In my junior year, I earned the lab manager position in Dr. Amie Gordon's Well-Being, Health, and Interpersonal Relationships lab, a role typically reserved for post-baccalaureate candidates. Being the only undergraduate in many of our research meetings made me especially attentive to how power and experience shape who feels comfortable asking questions and contributing intellectually. This perspective guides how I hope to contribute to Cornell's community—by uplifting voices in research, regardless of background or presentation. As a lab manager for the past four years, I've mentored eight poster presentations with undergraduate research assistants, three of whom received awards for excellence in research and presentation. When I joined Dr. Kurt Gray's Deepest Beliefs Lab, I met with an undergraduate senior weekly to design her honors thesis and served on her thesis committee, which received an Honors Distinction. These experiences taught me how people thrive when they know their questions are welcome, and that my role as a mentor is to make research spaces accessible, not intimidating. I balanced these mentorship responsibilities while working throughout college to support myself financially, which strengthened my ability to help others even under pressure.

My commitment to mentorship extends beyond the research lab. In my junior year, I was one of twenty upperclassmen selected as a Psychology Academic Peer Advisor. I led weekly one-on-one sessions with other students to select courses, plan their majors, and hone their research interests. In my senior year, I was one of two undergraduates chosen for the Academic Affairs committee. Alongside faculty and administrators, we reviewed course content, considered new courses, and handled academic dishonesty cases. These roles made it clear to me

that academia works best when it is a collaborative space driven by multiple transparent perspectives from all levels.

Beyond mentorship, another passion of mine is science communication. I currently co-author the Substack newsletter *Moral Understanding* with Dr. Gray, contributing to twelve pieces on how science helps us understand real-world topics, with an average of 2.5k readers per piece. Each essay connects psychological science to current issues in law, morality, and policy. I also co-organized the inaugural *Science to Impact* conference at The Ohio State University, which trained researchers on how to share scientific findings with the public. Sharing research with these outside audiences reinforced my belief that science is strongest when it is transparent, accessible, and inclusive. These are values that make me ready to contribute to collaborative research at Cornell.

Alongside developing new skills, I have served as a lab manager at three different universities, making me experienced at adapting to new research environments. Each move meant unpacking and starting over with new systems, norms, and research cultures. Navigating these transitions on my own taught me how to build community from scratch and adapt quickly to unfamiliar systems—skills that will make me a supportive, resilient member of a graduate cohort. Seeing how research is conducted in different ways has sharpened my interests and made me more adaptable; I feel truly ready for anything.

Looking back, my motto at nine years old—*In omnia paratus*—best describes how I approach scholarship and community. I want to bring that commitment to Cornell, where I believe the environment is best suited for me to pursue my research goals. I hope to contribute not only as a researcher but also as someone committed to creating spaces where students feel confident asking questions and exploring ideas.